FUGEES



WASHED AWAY
The residents of Notun Shibpur, Murshidabad, survey the ruins of what was once their home

The river they once knew so well now seems to be turning on the people living on either side of the 150-km stretch of the Ganga upstream and downstream of the Farakka Barrage in West Bengal. Bit by bit, it has been shifting course, and eating into their lands. Some 400 square kilometres of it, to be precise, across 15 blocks in the Malda, Murshidabad and Nadia districts. So reveals a recent report by the West Bengal government. Even places that saw no erosion in the past six decades have now become vulnerable, it seems.

As a result, lakhs of people in the vicinity of the river live with the constant threat of erosion and the consequent loss of home and hearth. Heavy sedimentation upstream, multiple dams on the river that do not leave enough water for the sedimentation to be pushed into the delta, and an erratic weather pattern are altering the river's natural course, forcing it to breach the banks and dislodge the soil. That, in turn, has led to widespread displacement of people, with neither the Centre nor the state offering them anything by way of succour, monetary or otherwise.

Sreemanti Mondal, a *bidi* worker in her late 30s who lives in Bhimagram in Malda, recounts the nightmare of last year as though it were yesterday. "It was past midnight," she says. "I was fast asleep. My cat alerted me. I rushed out to see the minarets of the nearby mosque swinging. Soon, the water began entering my house. It first took away the courtyard, and then the toilet and kitchen." The river-facing side of her two-storeyed house went under as did her mango orchard.

Around the same time, fortysomething Mohammad Rabi-ul Islam lost 30 bighas. He would sleep in the courtyard of the mosque with others as he had no place to stay. In September 2021, the mosque was washed away too, along with a 100-year-old high school building, two temples and several other concrete structures.